

6.1 Some History

Contrary to popular misconception, “spam” is not an abbreviation for “Stupid Pointless Annoying Messages.” The term, in the context of e-mail, came from the now-famous Monty Python Spam Sketch. Monty Python’s Flying Circus, an early comedy show on the BBC, showed a scene set in a café where every item on the menu had something or the other to do with SPAM meat. (SPAM is a brand of luncheon meat that was rationed to British soldiers in World War II.)

The idea of using this terminology for spam came about when certain users on bulletin boards used to scroll other users’ text off the screen by repeating the word “spam” over and over again. They also used several references from the Monty Python scene to achieve their purpose. This sparked off the use of the term “spam” in the way that we know it today.

Spam has grown from being just a means of annoyance to a means of annoying marketing. So now you have, apart from people trying to annoy the hell out of you, people trying to sell you a variety of products you don’t really need, at prices you couldn’t care less about, using up precious time you really can’t afford to spend.

6.2 Phishing

Back to your Inbox: “Get a replica Rolex cheap.” “Increase your sexual performance by triple!” “I’m a lonely housewife...” As you scroll through one after the other ridiculous offer, your eye catches something different.

“Before I start, I must first apologise for this unsolicited mail to you... My US client, his wife and children were involved in a ghastly motor accident on such-and-such road in Nigeria ... My reason for contacting you is to repatriate my client’s money back to his home country. We need to transfer money into your bank